

is considering more investment in these sectors.

During the pandemic, the Economic Revival Committee suggested that every village have zones demarcated for community markets to enable storage, sales and packaging systems that are connected to taluka markets. A cluster approach is being proposed to promote value chains for select crops.

Earlier this year, the central government hiked the budget to modernise rural infrastructure in Goa by five times. As much as Rs 500 crore is being pumped into the state to improve development that is expected to benefit farmers, animal rearers and fisherfolk. The minimum support price of coconut and cashew nut was increased by 20 per cent and 25 per cent respectively in 2020-21.

Numerous schemes including the Assured Price Crop Compensation Scheme, Kamdhenu Scheme, Community Dairy Farming Scheme, Pashupalan Scheme, Dairy Equipment Scheme and Fodder Development Scheme are bringing benefits to more than 40,000 farmers in Goa.

Thousands have also benefited from the Pradhan Mantri Kisan Samman Nidhi Yojana, which provides small and marginal farmers with an additional source of income of Rs 6000 per year.

The fishing community has also received various types of assistance including a subsidy on loans up to Rs 5 lakhs to purchase fishing equipment, 50 per cent subsidy on setting up aquaculture farms and a subsidy of Rs 30 per litre on a maximum consumption of 1700 litres of petrol.

A mega fish festival was held this year, along with the launch of the Matsya Setu app, the Goa State Mariculture Policy and a ban on LED fishing.

FUNDING THE FUTURE

The state government aims to improve education across the board, raising access to better quality education in rural areas and also looking at becoming an education hub through tie ups with private universities.

It has been working on implementing measures from the National Education Policy, while also investing heavily - as much as Rs 60 crores - in technical education. Prime Minister Modi has himself lauded the Chief Minister's initiatives to include training for coding and robotics in schools through partnerships with hardware and software companies known globally for high quality equipment, training and knowledge.

An e-portal (DISHTAVO) and state board app have been launched to provide information on study materials, question papers, notifications and circulars to students across Goa. To encourage creative thinking among young minds, Chief Minister Dr Sawant inaugurated an innovation hub at the Goa Science Centre.

During the pandemic, important academic and competitive examinations were conducted with various safety measures in place. In addition, the state waived off half the tuition, gymkhana and cultural fees for academic admissions in all colleges under the purview of the Directorate of Higher Education.

According to reports, Goa ranks highest for its infrastructure at school levels and human resources. The state also boasts one of the best ratios for girls in higher education in India, and the third best pupil-teacher ratio in the country.

Funds have been allotted for smart classrooms, development of laboratories, improved sanitary facilities, and scholarship programmes for orphans. The government is also working to set up a permanent campus for Indian Institute of Technology in the state. The foundation stone for the National Forensic Science University was laid by Union Home Minister Amit Shah which will usher in a new era in forensic science in India.

SWAYAMPURNA GOA

The Atmanirbhar Bharat Abhiyan or Self-Reliant India campaign is a vision by Prime Minister Narendra Modi to make the country and its citizens independent particularly in economy, infrastructure, systems, vibrant demography and demand.

Inspired by this call, Goa Chief Minister Dr Pramod Sawant devised the Swayampurna Goa initiative, launched in October 2020 with special state government officers appointed to carry out various tasks in panchayats and municipalities.

The objective is to ensure every village in the state becomes self-reliant by harnessing locally available resources. The action plan covers agriculture, animal husbandry, tourism, fisheries and natural resources. It also involves issues related to youth and adolescents, senior citizens, women and self-help groups through various schemes and their convergence.

In February 2021, the central government allocated Rs 300 crore to celebrate the 60th anniversary of Goa's liberation, which the Chief Minister promised would focus on creating a blue economy in Goa which is beneficial to its people.

He had said, "The allocated amount will not only be used for infrastructure development, but also for human development under the Swayampurna Goa scheme." His initiatives have so far been praised by the Prime Minister when he interacted with the state government officers and beneficiaries of the programme.

Modi said, "Goa has achieved 100 per cent target in many programmes. It has achieved its target of 100 per cent electricity connection to every household. India set the goal of being free from open defecation. Goa reached this mark as well. In Har Ghar Jal Abhiyan, Goa was the first state to accomplish this goal. The state also obtained 100 per cent in providing free ration to the poor. Schemes for women are being successfully implemented at the ground level in Goa. The infrastructure being developed in the state will help in increasing the income of farmers, animal rearers, and fisherfolk. In 2021, the fund for modernisation of the rural infrastructure in Goa has been increased by five times compared to last year."

He further pointed out that the successful stories of the Swayampurna Goa initiative are the product of innovative, sensitive and responsible bureaucracy. "Goa means nature and tourism, but today it also means a new